

Crick and Watson's discovery that DNA is composed of a double helix structure proved to be one of the greatest scientific discoveries of the 20th century. DNA (or deoxyribonucleic acid) is the chemical substance within cells that determines hereditary patterns in all living things.

Working out its structure helped scientists learn how it can replicate and pass on genetic information and provided crucial insight into how genes work.

The DNA race

When Crick and Watson met in 1951, a global race to discover the structure of DNA had already begun. In 1944, US immunologist Oswald Avery had discovered that DNA carries genetic information, but without

***Discovering the famous** double helix structure of DNA enabled the launch of new scientific techniques, such as gene sequencing and genetic engineering. It also opened up vast areas of research into inherited medical conditions.*